

Under the Banner of the New York City Subway

- Pragya Aryal



121
Years

25 subway
lines

472 subway
stations

5.5 million +
daily riders

Share your Story



Love letter to subway

Dear Subway,
Most people in New York City spend 1/4 of
their life moving through you
and some avoid you like the plague.
Some like you very much
and some hate you with passion.
I have a love-hate relationship with you.
I like you. [read more](#)

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"Public Space"
- the Subway

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Do I see them
or do I just
make them
invisible?

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Banner of New
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Subway



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Website : <https://pragyaaryal.com.np/Subway/map>



My Introduction to Public Space

As a part of my CityGap application in May of 2025, exactly a year ago, Tanya and Andy asked me to build a neighbourhood biography that included 3 meaningful spaces in my neighbourhood (Kapan, Kathmandu). In the application, unaware of the significance of the realm of public space, 2 out of the 3 places that I chose were *surprise surprise* public spaces: Lakhepokhari Community Park and *Didi Bahini ko Basibiyalo* (Older-Younger Sister's Community). The first one is owned and managed by the local government - a Public Space with a capital 'P', and the other was created within the community by women of the neighborhood - a lowercase 'p' public space.

I never really thought much of public spaces. (neither 'P' nor 'p')

In early September, when I first came to New York City, Tanya & Andy threw me head first into the chaos that is New York City. Suddenly, I was navigating the subway, walking up Broadway, roaming through museums, learning about public housing, examining Open Streets, Plazas, and Public-Private Partnerships, holding discussions on historical monuments, and re-imagining remembrance and memory through the lens of privilege and access, justice and equity — all of which left me confused, filled with questions, excited and curious to learn more.

BUT I kept thinking about Kathmandu, and the open space that no longer exists where I spent a month after the earthquake in 2015; the park in front of my house that took almost 10 years to come to life; the space a group of mothers created in our neighborhood to open their homes to each other; Handigaun's car free street that reflects the history of Kathmandu; evening walks to Boudha (world heritage site); multiple hikes to Shivapuri National Park (my favorite place). Suddenly I realized I was analyzing all these types of public spaces that shaped the life around me.

It also left me wondering if the only reason I felt at peace going to temples in Kathmandu was because they are one of the only remaining open spaces where one can sit and reflect.

"We should focus on more important issues like health and education. And roads and transit and flooding that take away so many lives every year in Nepal." This sentiment echoes in the minds of most Nepali people and it is not unreasonable to feel that way. While we are struggling to meet our basic needs, we may think access to public space is just a far-fetched dream, or something that comes with privilege. And maybe we are right.

As a 21 year-old on a gap year, I had the privilege to be in New York City and learn about the creation of public spaces in New York City, and their significance while also learning about

public spaces back in Kathmandu. It's funny to think that I had to come all the way to New York City to learn about my own home.

My initial approach to public space came from a place of skepticism, questioning, and curiosity. Last semester, I tried to transform those feelings into a sense of hope through a [policy memo](#) that drew on New York City's experiences to explore practical ways to manage and improve public spaces in Kathmandu.

This semester, I have moved away from facts and policies, and chosen to contemplate my favorite public space through personal memories, experiences, and observations, using stories to build a web archive.

My Favorite “Public Space” – the Subway

After studying public spaces, some in the South Bronx as part of our group project with the Department of Transportation last semester, and writing a 32-page comparative analysis on public spaces in NYC and Kathmandu, I would like to call myself sort of an expert, and feel confident making the following conclusion: **Subways make for the best public space.**

For my purposes here, I define public space as the transformation- purposeful, circumstantial or serendipitous- of *space* into a *place* where people gather intentionally, or even unintentionally, to become part of a community, feeling a sense of connection.

Every time someone asks,

“So what’s your favorite thing about New York City?”

My reply rolls off the tip of my tongue, “Subways ...”

There’s always a pause then, it’s like they’re waiting for me to say.... BAZZINGA! and then they go,

“Why?”

“....they’re so dirty!”

“They’re not that safe..you know”

“They stink like piss and weed”

I think I even said that when I first came to New York City... but hear me out!

Most benches, even in public parks, often are not facing each other, but the seats in subway cars do face each other, which puts you in close proximity to other people, from a diverse set of circumstances, in a space open to anyone who can afford the fare (or not), for a set duration of time, and makes it a perfect setting to have impromptu conversations, chime in to the gossip among a friend group or between a couple, smile at random kids, and be annoyed by a screaming toddler.

“Democracy does not require perfect equality, but it does require that citizens share a common life. What matters is that people of different backgrounds and social positions encounter one another, and bump up against one another, in the course of everyday life. For this is how we learn to negotiate and abide our differences, and how we come to care for the

common good.”

– Michael J. Sandel

I just quoted a philosopher, so you know I am serious about this!

Last semester I stumbled upon this quote, and my immediate thought was, *the subway!* The subway helps make New York more democratic. It's not a perfect democracy, far from it, but the subway plays an active role in creating democratic places in the city.

Subways- cars and station platforms- create space for people to come together— finance bros dressed in crisp suits and polished shoes, sleep deprived college students, either returning from a party at 3 am or leaving for classes at 9, service workers taking naps during their early morning ride back home, unhoused individuals sleeping on the benches that are designed to keep them out (at some stations they've been removed and replaced with stupid leaning bars), undocumented women selling candies and fruits with their baby on their back, CEOs typing emails and trying to join a Zoom call on their cell in the very small window of time they have between leaving their office and getting on the train, entrepreneurs trying to catch up on work with a book in hand, commuters slowing their pace to take in the performances, singers drawing people out of their routine, dancers fist bumping upside down, all kinds of people—old, young, rich, poor, newcomers, old-timers, queer, straight, racist, homophobic, kind, calm, loud—and it is open to anyone who has \$3 or can jump or slide through the turnstiles.

When I think of NYC and its diversity, the subway captures its true essence!!

The subway has been in operation for 121 years; there are 22+ subway lines and 472 subway stations with 5.5 million daily riders! The numbers are CRAZY. But what happens inside those subway stations, and in what ways each one of those individuals interacts with the subway, is what fascinates me.

Here are my personal stories, my encounters, my journey though the New York City subway...

1. My First Subway Ride – More than Just Directions

Piss and Weed, that was my first impression of the New York City Subway.

My first subway ride was on *September 1, 2025* when I came here with my aunt's family from Long Island to go to Coney Island. I didn't even realize when we had switched from the Long Island Rail Road (LIRR) to the underground subway station. I was following my family and holding my 3-year old cousin's tiny hand. The place smelled funky and I remember the orange letterhead, the Q train. At first, we accidentally hopped on a subway that went in the opposite direction instead of the one to Coney Island. Some of my uncle's friends, who've lived in Long Island for over 10 years and rarely come into the city, were navigating, and we immediately got off at the next station to switch to the right train. That's when I handed my little cousin over to my aunt and pulled out my Google Maps to see if I could navigate.

I like knowing things. I like taking charge and I like being in control of my surroundings. Not to say that I didn't trust the older adults doing their job, it's just always been my job back home with my friends, to navigate and get us to the right places. But here I didn't know what I was navigating. I saw a bunch of trains, locations and times in Google Maps but it didn't click. I've spent my whole life navigating narrow alleys in Nepal, weaving through traffic, pedestrians, vendors, and parked cars at the same time while on a scooter, so I expected I'd be able to figure this out too. But I couldn't fully make sense of the system, so I gave up and just followed the crowd.

My aunt looked lost too, her hands full as my cousin tried to run around the platform. I asked her, "Have you been to New York City from Long Island before using the subway?"

She had moved to Long Island in 2021, almost five years ago. When she moved here, she learned how to drive and started using her car to go everywhere. I knew she drove to work and everywhere else, but I wondered if she ever still used the subway to come into the city.

She reminisced about her time in London in her thirties and said, "I used to be so good at it. I took myself out often, met friends in the city, navigated the trains, and explored new places on my own. But now I mostly just follow other people and make sure your cousin doesn't run away."

After a pause, she added, "Sometimes I feel like people assume I'm not smart enough because I'm just following them now. But outside of looking after your cousin, I just don't have the energy to care."

That day, I did not navigate the subway myself. I followed everyone else through the station and onto the train. But when I moved to New York City a week later, I started exploring and learning

my way around on my own. Looking back, I do not think my aunt had become less independent or less capable. Her life had simply changed because she had someone else to think about before herself. I was still in my 20s, with only myself to look after, and I realized I wanted to use that freedom.

Learning the subway became more than just directions. It became my way of exploring the city, making choices on my own, and proving to myself that I could move through the world independently. At the same time, I started to see how the subway is not only about independence, but also about access and ease. It can feel simple when you have time, energy, and no one depending on you. But it can feel much harder when you are caring for someone else and carrying that responsibility with you.

2. My Journey to the Express Train

I think I have spent a quarter of my time in New York City on the subway. When I first came to the city, for the CityGAP Program with Living City Project, I liked the 6 local trains. It took me to FOUND, at 51st Street and Lexington, where we had most of our classes. On Wednesdays, I went to La Morada in the South Bronx to volunteer for a few hours, and fortunately the 6 train went to a nearby station there as well.

I hated changing trains because every time I entered a new station, it felt like entering a new world, and it was. So the 6 was perfect for me, and I stayed loyal to it even though it stopped at every station. Had I switched to the 4 or 5 express trains, I probably could have saved some time, but I still could not fully differentiate between the local and express trains. So I spent an extra ten minutes getting somewhere on a familiar route rather than switching trains.

But New York didn't let me avoid learning forever.

On Saturdays, I went to 34th Avenue Open Street in Queens for bicycle rides. I could no longer rely on just one train. I took the 6 to Grand Central and switched to the 7. On weekends, I took whichever of the 1, 2, or 3 arrived first to Penn Station and then switched to the Long Island Rail Road (LIRR) to visit my aunt's family in Long Island.

I started slow. I began switching trains here and there, while still heavily relying on Google Maps to navigate and sticking mostly to local trains. I can be stubborn.

But I had to hasten my learning process when I moved to the Bronx for the last month of the semester. Only one line went to where I lived, and I had to take it all the way to 242nd Street–Van Cortlandt Park and then walk another fifteen minutes. To get to FOUND, I had to switch between three trains every day, turning my commute into an hour and fifteen minutes each way.

Most people would think that living in the Bronx would make it easier for me to travel to the South Bronx, but the opposite was true. It took me nearly one hour and forty minutes to travel from one side of the Bronx to the other, longer than getting to the South Bronx from Lower Manhattan, which took around forty minutes. I realized that it is often easier to travel into Manhattan from any borough than to travel between neighborhoods within the same borough, because most train lines were historically built to run through Manhattan, making cross-borough connections limited. I often had to go all the way back through Manhattan and then uptown again to get to the other side of the Bronx.

By the end of that semester, I still was not fluent in the subway system, but I could navigate almost anywhere with enough patience and Google Maps. To my surprise, I never once took a taxi. I did not even have Uber on my phone.

Then I went back to Nepal for two months, where there were no trains to navigate.

When I came back for another semester, I dragged my huge suitcase from Penn Station (LIRR) to the Upper West Side on a 2 express train by myself.

I started taking the 2 or 3 express train from 96th Street to Wall Street for work several days a week. The ride takes around twenty-four minutes; on the 1 train it would take nearly forty because it stops at every station. That is how I became fluent in express trains.

Ironically, local trains that once comforted me now test my patience. Whenever there are delays on the 2 or 3, I get annoyed at having to take the 1 instead.

I have taken the A train to Far Rockaway with beautiful views of the beach, but there are always delays. I have taken the L to Williamsburg, the G to Prospect Park, and the B and D on a few occasions, but I still don't know their stops. I can, however, look at a subway map in any station and tell where I can switch trains and where I am at that moment. I do not solely rely on Google Maps, and when my phone is about to die, I am very grateful for that skill. I am confident now that I can navigate most places without having to peek at my phone every few minutes. This newfound confidence makes me feel more independent and connected to the city.

Each subway line I have taken has a different story to tell. Each accommodates people with different colors of skin, each has a number of languages spoken on it, and the smell in the air changes from perfumes to flowers to food to sweat to piss. The styles of clothing vary too. I noticed the shift in diversity of commuters at each station and in the neighborhoods they exist in during my journey from local to express.

Sometimes, taking the 6, I would watch finance bros get on and off the train from 23rd Street to Midtown, or, taking the 1, I would see an increasing number of unhoused men and unkept subway stations above 125th Street, or taking the 7 train I'd see it hold the Asian diaspora, or taking the 3 train from 96th Street to Wall Street, I watched older professional men and women with established careers and young people who had just started theirs, get off and rush to their offices.

I can go on and on about how each line tells a story, how every person riding from the far tip of the Bronx to Lower Manhattan has different stops and purposes in mind, and how they sometimes meet in the middle, sit shoulder to shoulder, yet share nothing but those quiet moments.

For now, this is my story of learning to switch from the local to the express and navigate the subway city. There are still so many lines I have not taken yet and so many stations that are unfamiliar to me. These were just some of my experiences navigating the subway, centered mostly in Manhattan, and sometimes the Bronx and Queens. I don't know if I will come back. I

may move somewhere else halfway across the world, but I know now that I can safely navigate and return home through the New York City subway, at any time of the day — or night.

Where you live and the train near you dictates how you experience New York City!

Here are the most common subway lines I took over a period of eight months in NYC:

- ❖ 6 train Brooklyn Bridge City Hall → 51St. & Lexington Av (23 minutes)
- ❖ 6 train from Brooklyn Bridge City Hall → 3 av - 138 St, South Bronx (40 minutes)
- ❖ 6 train from Brooklyn Bridge City Hall → 7 train from Grand Central Station → 90 St–Elmhurst Av, Queens (47 minutes)
- ❖ 1 train from 242nd St Van Cortland Park → 7 train from 42nd St Times Square Station → 6 train from Grand Central Station → 51St Lexington Av (1 hr, 15 mins)
- ❖ 6 train from 51St Lexington Av → 7 train from Grand Central Station → 1 train from 42nd St Times Square → 242nd St Van Cortland Park (1 hr, 15 mins)
- ❖ 1 train from 242nd St Van Cortland Park → 7 train from 42nd St Times Square → 6 train from Grand Central Station → 3 av - 138 St, South Bronx (1 hour, 40 minutes)
- ❖ 2 or 3 train from 96th St → Wall Street (24 minutes)
- ❖ 2 or 3 train from 96th St → 7 train from 42nd St –Times Square Station → 6 train from Grand Central Station → 51St Lexington Av (24 minutes)

3. Subway Etiquette – Insider’s Rules to Navigate the Underground City

One of the many reasons I like New York is because of its people, who are infamous for being rude. In reality, New Yorkers are the kindest people I have ever met; however, they are also the most annoyed people, and rightfully so. This city is overwhelming, and if you’re not constantly moving, the crowd, delays, and constant interruptions can drain your energy over the course of the day.

Because New Yorkers are impatient, and the city is dense, and there is so much to do and see, here are some things to keep in mind while navigating the subway—the insider’s rules- some are spoken, some are unspoken, some are plastered in subway cars yet people choose to ignore them, and some you learn along the way...

- Wait for people to get off the train before you get in.... Again WAIT for people to get out and stand at the side of the door for them to leave before getting in.
- Do not stand by the door, get in and find a seat or get out of the way if there is space.
- Do not “manspread,” I repeat do not “manspread”. Do not take up more space than necessary. Be conscious of the people around you who may need the seat.
- Try to avoid headphones on the subway. Even if you are wearing headphones, do not play your music too loudly so you do not miss announcements or become unaware of your surroundings. 101 tips to maintain safety and connection.
- (Personal Preference) Stop being so touchy and all lovey couples... in the beginning I used to go awww, now I’m just annoyed that it's not me...HATER.
- When someone is rushing and the doors are about to close, try and hold it open for them. One day someone will return the favor for you as well. (not advised unless they're actually running and deserve the help, because you don't want to cause delays by holding the door for too long)
- If someone asks you for directions, always always help them out, as a New Yorker you are bound to help people navigate and flex your knowledge of the city and sense of direction.
- If you can afford to pay the fare, PAY the fare, MTA heavily relies on fares to cover its operation and maintenance costs!
- If you see something, keep moving and reach a safe space before you say something, unless someone is nearby whom you can tell right away.
- Ask for directions, if needed, people are always willing to help.
- Carry a book, crochet, something to do outside of trying to look busy on your phone or playing stupid games. Most people carry a book. It’s not pretentious and you build a good habit of reading an actual book. And people may engage you in a conversation about what you’re reading. It may even lead to a potential date....
- Get used to performers and music. Sometimes it’ll get overwhelming, but sometimes it's fun. You never know who needs that little bit of fun today to get through life. It may be YOU.

- Be annoyed by the loss of subway benches! They keep removing them and replacing them with leaning bars. It's STUPID AND HOSTILE! People need a place to sit and rest.
- Do not take up the entire pole and wrap your arms around it while on your phone preventing anyone else from using it. Leave space for others to hold on. Duh!
- DO NOT keep your bags on the seat next to you that could otherwise be used by someone to sit, unless it's an empty car with enough space for all.
- If someone is holding the emergency door open and telling you to get in, it's better to use the turnstile and pay the fare. PAY the fare! 39% of MTA's operation and maintenance cost relies on the fare.
- I know it's inconvenient to have delays and get stuck in the middle of the train lines, but do not lose your empathy and humanity, be patient.
- It's the best place to people-watch! But remember not to stare at people for too long.
- You can always switch your subway car at the next stop if you don't feel comfortable. Never feel you have to stay in a car that is making you anxious.
- Always take in your surroundings on the subway. There is so much life happening around you at all times. Soak it up!

4. Do I See Them or Do I Make Them Invisible?

I always receive a call from my aunt at nine in the morning, but it's really my four-year-old cousin on FaceTime. He is always so excited to see me. The first thing he asks is when I'm leaving for work and heading out of the house. The excitement is not really for me...

I show him the streets, the cars passing by, the changing traffic lights, as we make our way toward the most thrilling thing: the subway. He loves the subway, just as I do. During the entire call he is focused and quiet. He always waits to read the station name aloud - "96 Street Station (1) (2) (3)." He lives in Long Island, so most of his adventures entail either grocery shopping, malls or a quiet empty park nearby. For him, the New York City subway and the people who take it are amusing. He turned four recently. He was born in the US; I come from Nepal, and this world of the city is completely different, and subways are equally or more fascinating to me.

As always, I came down to the platform and prepared to show my cousin the trains coming and going, but today there was a woman walking around the platform, taking her clothes off, making faces, and screeching. She was probably in her late 30s or early 40s and had layers of unkempt clothing that she was pulling off her body, moving as if she were having some sort of fit. My train was right there on the platform, and before I could fully process what was happening, I got on it. It was during rush hour, and there were a fair number of people on the platform. Many of us were tightly packed into the last car in front of which she stopped. Normally, when I'm about to catch the train and it's there, it goes by so quickly that I hardly have time to get in. Today, even after I got in, there was some time before the doors actually closed, and I saw her twist her body and scream in pain. I watched the screaming woman jerking her body as she moved around the small platform (the 96th Street platform is one of the smallest). Most of us seemed visibly scared that she might enter the car, into the tight space that we were in. I don't know if anyone called for help. I don't know if she was there for a while. I watched her scream from the train platform as my train left, and only after my phone call with my cousin dropped as I lost service, I realized he might have heard some of that too. I don't know if, in future, when he explores New York City on his own, how much of it he will like, if he will take the subways and get déjà vu from so many times I've shown him the platform, or if he will not take the subway at all to avoid such encounters.

I've gotten so used to encountering events like that, I thought to myself. Every time there is an unhoused person sleeping on one of those uncomfortable benches designed to keep them away, I walk past as if I don't fully see them. I see someone asleep on the floor, covered in food scraps, sweat and piss, and I hold my breath and keep walking. When someone enters a car and I think they might cause a scene, I switch cars as soon as I can. I see women selling candies with a baby strapped to their backs, and I keep to myself.

There is no reason to engage, and, more often than not, I've been advised not to make eye contact. One time, I mistakenly looked at a guy painting on a subway map inside the car. The stranger came near me stomping his feet, trying to scare me off, because I looked at him spray painting. I was with Collins, a friend in my program, on my way to our meeting on 51st St, and Collins spoke on my behalf, "Man what are you trying to do that for?" The stranger moved a little further and I tried to keep my cool and asked Collins to not engage any further because I didn't want to cause a scene. It was a moving car, we couldn't have gotten out of it, and there were only a few of us. That's also maybe the reason he felt comfortable vandalizing. What would I have done in that situation if my friend hadn't been there? I think part of my hesitation came from being a woman, and his willingness to engage came from him being a man. I have heard my friends who are men talk about taking the subway alone at three in the morning while sloshed, and I cannot imagine moving through the city with that same ease or lack of fear. Even though I have grown to love the subway and feel safe most of the time, there is only so much risk I am willing to take, because public spaces, no matter where they are, are experienced differently by men and women.

There's always a constant tension for me between: do I see the unhoused men, the strangers vandalizing the subway cars, undocumented women selling fruit, people who seem to be struggling and sleeping on the benches or do I make them invisible?

A few weeks ago, I was in Grand Central Station on my way to Queens for a bicycle ride. I stepped out of the station to meet a friend and travel with them. They're not used to navigating the subway on their own. They've been in New York City longer than I have. They walk to their work and live 10 minutes from their workplace. Finance bros. Murray Hill. Rings a bell, no?

I met them in Grand Central Station around 9:20-ish and took the 7 train to Queens. 8-10 minutes later, on the same platform, a 7 train coming into Grand Central carried someone with a knife who slashed three random people on that very platform. We learned this news later, around 11pm, in a social media post from a New York City fan page while returning from our cycle ride. We were waiting for our train and they announced that the trains were no longer stopping at Grand Central.

When I described this situation to my sister back in Nepal over a call, I don't know why but I started with, 'It's funny' (It's not). She looked clearly shocked by my casualness about something like that happening nearby. But there's only so much you can do, so I calmed my nerves by downplaying its impact. Maybe it is also about feeling overwhelmed by having to confront so much at once. It becomes both a way of handling it and survival, but also a way of defending ourselves from it, and I know the system is one of the safest in the world, but because it is so heavily used, about 5.5 million riders on an average weekday, things can still happen, even if that does not mean it is unsafe.

I have had many such encounters that have made me feel unsafe and overwhelmed, but I have also had moments that I treasure. Both things can be true at the same time. And maybe I am still deflecting, and maybe I am still downplaying the weight of these situations.

Over time, I have also been learning to see people and extend kindness, even if I cannot always give money or support. When I see someone selling food, or performing, or sleeping in the subway, I try to be respectful. Even if I am not buying the candy, I can still smile. Even if I am not paying the performers, I can still clap. And when I have leftovers, I can sometimes give them to unhoused people.

I can also go on and on about access and equity in the subway, and how much of my experience is shaped by that. I can keep my distance, but I can also still extend myself. After all, we are all part of the same system. We are the subway.

5. Under the Banner of the New York City Subway

I remember reading an essay early on in our program which spoke about how New Yorkers move fast and with intention from one place to another, but they also come together when needed before dispersing just as quickly because “that’s what New Yorkers do.”

“Yes, we ‘carry on,’ after disaster and attack, but that’s not all we do. We also function pretty well day-to-day, with our multiple gods, and none, with our graven images, and our Babel of languages.”

— *Under the Banner of New York, Zadie Smith (November 4, 2017)*

Subways are systems of transport and circulation: people coming in from all directions with a set destination, dispersing as quickly as they can. Yet they also create moments to slow down and linger. Within a closed car, strangers sit shoulder to shoulder in close proximity, sharing the same moving time. People read books, crochet, listen to podcasts or music, play mobile games, or scroll through the same screens they were reading when they woke up. There is an intimacy in this enforced closeness.

I’ve seen people put down their phones to fist-bump a group of showtime performers, a woman joining in on carols, and tourists asking for directions with New Yorkers kindly providing them. I’ve seen people playing the most beautiful tunes on violins, using buckets as drums to build infectious rhythms, dancing with life-sized dolls of women, and selling flutes and beads they claimed were from the African subcontinent. I’ve also encountered people leaving the car bothered by the invasion of that little enclosed space, the subway car, during one too many performances. I’ve held doors for strangers, and some have done the same for me. We shift to make space for each other, leave room for everyone to hold onto the poles, and some days a person loops their arm around one just to keep scrolling through their phone if their hands are full. I’ve been elated by some performances and exhausted and irritated by others. This same space also holds discomfort through delays caused by emergencies, encounters with individuals cursing very loudly, and sometimes screaming, and the atmosphere of frustration over missed appointments and disrupted routines.

E.B. White, in one of his essays, writes about New York as a city filled with contradictions, where people can feel both deeply alone and completely surrounded at the same time. That tension exists constantly in the subway. Everyone moves through the same cramped space with different destinations and emotions. Even in moments of silence or traveling long distances together, there is still a shared understanding that comes from experiencing the city together.

“On any person who desires such queer prizes, New York will bestow the gift of loneliness and the gift of privacy.”

— E.B. White, *Here Is New York*, 1949

The subway gives you the gift of loneliness and connection, celebration and exhaustion, kindness and frustration. People care for each other while also making some people invisible. The subway is a paradox. It is designed for movement, for people to enter and exit, not to stay. Yet I’ve seen it produce moments of pause, connection, and art. So many of the encounters, experiences, and lessons I’ve had in this city have been in the liminal subway. And this is my attempt at archiving those moments and memories.

9:47 PM, 4th December 2025, 125th St, 1 train

Last December as we approached our final weeks in the program, Christmas was around the corner, and it had started freezing outside. I was constantly cold and kept falling into patterns of sleep–work–sleep. It was late evening, I was in a crowded car, everyone seemed tired, probably returning home from a long day of work. Two black men in their late 50s, wearing brown coats, with a soulful voice, started singing, and a woman, probably in her late 40s, wearing a blue beret and long woolen skirt, sitting next to the door in the same car, joined along, “*under the boardwalk, down by the sea....*” It suddenly brought me out of my sleep–work–sleep loop and made me feel connected to my fellow subway travelers. Subway performances have the power to pull you out from your routine and bring you into the moment.

4:20 PM, 20th October 2025, 6 train

I was coming home late in the afternoon, when I saw a young woman with blonde hair and a leather jacket holding a bouquet of Makhmali flowers (Globe Amaranth). In Nepal, we use those flowers to make garlands for Bhai Tika, the day during Tihar when we pray for the protection and longevity of our siblings. It was around the same time of year, and since the flowers are seasonal, seeing them made me feel so happy, because they gave me a sense of home, even while I was halfway across the world.

10:15 PM, December 9th, 2025 145th Station

After exactly three months of being in the city, I officially entered the subway without paying. I was returning home after working all day. I was tired and just wanted to crash, but the journey ahead was a 40-minute ride to 242nd at Van Cortlandt and then a 15-minute walk.

A man opened the emergency door for me from inside and asked me to get in as I was rummaging through my bag to find my OMNY card. I looked at him, he was wearing worn-out

jeans and a sweater not warm enough for the weather. I found my OMNY card inside my tote bag, but I didn't pull it out. I looked at the open emergency door next to the turnstile I was supposed to tap through, and I just went in because I felt like I couldn't say no.

5:00 PM, 19th March, 2026, 59th St Columbus Circle, 1 train

Kid #1 "Does your mom have my mom's number? I want to call you after."

Kid #2 pulling on Kid #1's mother, "Hey, Katie's mom, do you have my mom's number? I want to call Katie."

6-year-old kids sat on their knees on the subway seat, facing the window and talking about their day and wanting to talk more after. I wonder when they will be independently navigating the subway and having their own phones to call their friends. Time flies and they will be doing that in no time.

12:57 PM, 7th April, 2026 51st St, 6 train

"Dont treat me like my dad does" a performer voiced as he was getting ready for a show time performance and a person nearby stood up from their seat and moved as far as he could to not be included. Sometimes subway performances are overwhelming and sometimes it's fun. It's okay to not engage, but you never know who needs that little bit of fun today to get through life, and what a gift it might be to listen.

17:14 PM, 10th April, 2025, Times Sq-42 St, 7 train

A man in his 20s took out his computer and started working on a paper for a class, doing some integral equations, in the middle of the subway ride, and on a very packed train. I respect his drive.

8:20 PM, 30th September 2025, Houston St, 6 train

"AI is not your friend. It does not replace human connection." I saw someone write this on an advertisement for a chatbot AI- friend.com. I love that New Yorkers are very vocal about things they don't like. I remember seeing these advertisements all over the subway, comparing how your roommate may leave dishes unwashed, but AI won't (very creepy).

16th April 2026

“No pain No gain” advertisement for 800-Pain law.

“Accident? Call us!” with smiling faces and professional attire.

The creativity that comes out of the subway advertisements in NYC should be studied. Wait, maybe there are studies, I should check!

5:23 PM, 19th March 2026, Grand Central Station

When my friend from California visited me, we went to Grand Central to explore and take pictures. I remember going there in the early days when I first came to New York, and Andy showed us a place where you could talk at one corner of the space and hear the person from another corner. Nowadays, I am always in that station, but somewhere deep inside, at one of the platforms, switching between trains. I am in that station almost every day transferring, but I rarely get out of the platform to admire its beauty. Maybe this is what happens, and what you lose, when you become a daily commuter.

7:28 PM, 13th March 2026

The train I was on stopped for a few minutes which felt like hours and I was the only one in that car. WELP!

8:54 PM, 11th April 2026, Grand Central Station

I met an elderly Asian woman who had lived in NYC for more than 30 years, asking whether 5 Av was the next stop for the 7 train moving towards Queens. I replied yes, and I asked, not knowing, if she was new to New York. She said it's better to ask than get lost. She mentioned she now lives in Port Washington. Even native New Yorkers get lost sometimes.

8:21 PM, 9th March 2026, 34th St Hudson Yards

Only last September I was stepping into the subway for the first time, and, today, I met someone on a date who had never been on a subway. I was part of his first subway ride. I tried to explain uptown and downtown, and the express lines, and as I was explaining it, I realized how difficult

it must be for a new person to understand the subway immediately, since I was once in the same position. I've come full circle.

5:48 PM, B train, 23rd March, 2026 , Broadway-Laffayette St

Devi and I were returning from exploring New York, and as we were about to part ways, we were taking pictures on a subway, saying our goodbyes and thinking about when we would meet again. I am going back to Nepal in June, and she is in California for a couple of years. It was L-shaped seating, and I very rarely encounter subways with them because I rarely take the BMT lines. An older person sitting sideways in front of us saw us taking pictures and offered to take one for us <3. New Yorkers can be kind.

5:51 PM, 3rd December 2025

It was during rush hour and I was blasting "Heather" by Conan Gray, singing along to the lines "I still remember, 3rd of December, me in your sweater" as I watched an older couple holding onto each other in the subway. The subway creates such intimate spaces, with acts of holding the poles in a crowded car while still leaving room for others to grab them, the kindness of offering your seat, and goodbyes, hugs, and love, and staying with someone until they reach their destination. And also felt kind of bummed that I'm not dating anyone to have those moments.

4:43 PM, 16th February, 34th St Penn Station

As I dragged my suitcase from Penn Station's LIRR platform into the crowded subway, a stranger looked at me and my suitcase and asked, "Are you coming or going somewhere?"

"I'm coming back."

"Welcome back!"

"Thank you!!!"

I missed this city so much!

7:47 PM, 21st November 2025, 110th St

While the astronauts, heroes forever, spent mere hours on the moon, I have remained in this new world for nearly thirty years. I know that my achievement is quite ordinary. I am not the only man to seek his fortune far from home, and certainly I am not the first. Still there are times I am bewildered by each mile I have traveled, each meal I have eaten, each person I have known, each room in which I have slept. As ordinary as it all appears, there are times when it is beyond my imagination.

— Jhumpa Lahiri, *Interpreter of Maladies*, 1999

I read four books: ‘Namesake’, ‘Interpreter of Maladies’, ‘Normal People’ and ‘Everything I know about love’ during the many subway rides I took in the last eight months. Every time I see someone with a book I take a peek at what they're reading. I am very nosy at that.

5:09 PM, 7th October, 2025, 14th St, 6 train

A person seemingly in his late 20s had pamphlets and flyers in his hands. I was curious about what it was about, so I asked, “Are you coming from a protest or a march?” It was around the time of the No Kings March in New York, and I assumed he had come from that or was preparing for it. He gave me a pamphlet and said he had been fired from his position at a company for speaking about the Israel–Palestine War, and that it was a protest against the company. I had signed up to show support, and recently I got an email that he moved out of New York for another job.

9:20 AM, 8th April, 96th Street station

I was rushing to the train and I saw some religious pamphlets placed outside. I was taking my phone out to write about how the subway location and placement of religious pamphlets connect. While doing so, I missed a step and fell to the ground and a guy next to me rushing to the subway asked if I needed help but before I could even answer he had left.

On the same day, while I was returning home, someone gave their seat to me. I had a mild headache. I didn't mention any of that to him. He just saw me standing and offered his seat to me. Sometimes New Yorkers have a powerful sixth sense.

21 December 2025, Times Sq–42nd Street

Around December of 2025, I often encountered a young 20-something year old singing at the uptown 1/2/3 platform in Times Sq–42nd Street. She had speakers that created an echo of her

voice all across the platform, and I liked it at first. But after seeing her there almost every evening, I started thinking that maybe she could lower the volume a little. It becomes overwhelming when you're returning home after a long day of work and the music is blasting in your ears.... Now I really sound like a New Yorker. It happens before you even realize.

9:30 AM, 20th March 2026, 96th St

A brown woman in her late 20s carrying a small plastic book case in her hand was going around in the subway platform while waiting for the train until she saw me and stopped to ask if it was a safe neighbourhood. What's it like near the 96th Street station on the Upper West Side? I've been living here for a month now. I can safely say I've returned at 2 in the morning and made it home safe. She said she lives in FiDi and it's boring over there. I said a lot of university students live nearby so I think it's safe?

But I thought to myself, what does one consider safe?

4:25 PM, 34th Penn Station, 1 train, 1st May 2026,

I love the subway portal art—it has window-like scenes of different happenings and stories, beautifully designed inside the subway cars. It portrays how the subway is a portal to many different lives. (Thank you Shadra Strickland.) That is exactly how I think of the subway as well: a window into so many lives coming together.

9:54 AM, 7th May 2026, Cathedral Pkway (110St)

I love seeing people read books, crochet, play games, and write on the subway. I love that the cell connection doesn't always work inside subway cars. It forces people into having conversations and sometimes into talking about the book they are reading.

Share your Story!



Letter to Subway

Dear Subway,

Most people in New York City spend $\frac{1}{4}$ of their life moving through you
and some avoid you like the plague.

Some like you very much
and some hate you with a passion.

I have a love-hate relationship with you.

I like you.

You're not a specific place
or a specific train or even just one integrated system.
You're everything that's inside of you,
the people traveling,
the hostile architecture,
the beautiful mosaic tiles,
the unhoused individuals,
the woman carrying her children on her back and selling fruits,
the annoyed stranger who was trying to enter the car,
and also the tourist who stands right in front of the door and doesn't budge,
the couples who cannot for the love of god maintain some physical distance,
the kids with their knees on the seat turned towards the window watching life pass by,
you are all of them.

I cannot locate you.

But ***I know you.***

I know there is the good, the bad, and the ugly to you,
you consume this city
and you vomit this city,
you run underneath and elevated,
you bring people together
and lead them back.

I will not say you're the same to all, you are not.

For me, I can run into you and I can run out

I can choose to stand and I can find a seat in the middle of the car,

I know you try

and ***I adore you*** for that...

You are the pause in between the exhausting day of work and the quietude of home,
you are the songs and the music and the performers,
you are the overwhelming crowd, you're the loud noise and intrusive thoughts,
you are the art, beauty, culture and the melting pot,
you are the portal to the many many lives we live,
you're so many love stories

and also the missed connections,
so much warmth and so much hate,
you are also the stranger offering kindness
and the anonymous person being shot at your door step.
You've seen so many lose hope
but have also seen so many choose life everyday.
You've seen people complain about your old rusty looks
but also compliment you on your new attire
You've seen people cry and complain and laugh and jump,
you've seen it all.

121 years. 472 stations. 25 lines.

You hold together all kinds of people.
You've looked after the unhoused who often disappear into the shadows.
You've created homes and broken some.
You've held the pieces of NYC together.

It's crazy how much I love this city,
the pebble beach, the city skyline, the diversity,
the food, the people, the parks, the waterfront,
I can go on and on about the things I love about New York

But you, *you're my favorite of all,*
you make all of it possible.

Acknowledgement

To my Baba, who keeps insisting I write everything down, these writings are for you. To Mamu, all the visuals are for you, because you taught me to capture the beauty in tiny moments. And to my siblings, who annoy me the most and inspire me to leave home often—New York would not have happened otherwise.

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To Tanya and Andy, for teaching me to explore cities with intention, turning education into experience and New York into my home. Your kindness is contagious.

To the friends I've made along the way.

And to me, for never losing hope and always stepping out of my comfort zone.

THANK YOU!